AS EARLY AS 1927, when he accepted a position on the executive committee of the League against Imperialism alongside Albert Einstein and the Labour leader George Lansbury,[7] Nehru had emerged as the Congress party's primary spokesperson and thinker on external issues. Given a free hand by his Congress colleagues, he prepared for policymaking two decades before he gained executive power.[8] Many of his worldviews were formed in the crucible of Congress-led nationalist agitations. As one of the few Congress leaders interested in and conversant with world affairs, which he primarily interpreted using a progressive anti-imperialist lens and his own inclination towards socialist internationalism, he developed a deep interest in the broader anti-colonial struggle in Asia – particularly Southeast Asia and China, which he saw 'at once as peer, comrade and soul mate'[9] and of which he seemed to consider himself a patron.[10] Both his interest and his leanings were in full display at the Asian Relations Conference, which he hosted in New Delhi in March 1947 as an assertion of Asian solidarity against European domination, and where he called China 'that great country to which Asia owes so much'.[11]

Little wonder then, that when he finally ascended to the position of Prime Minister, Nehru believed himself to be especially qualified to also occupy the position of minister of external affairs where he proceeded to carve out foreign policy as his exclusive sphere; a turf he guarded jealously from any interference and over which he exercised vast, unchecked power.[12] It was a position that he had greatly coveted right from when the interim government had been proposed in 1946.[13] In this role, from 1947 to his death in 1964, Nehru almost single-handedly demarcated and interpreted India's goals and interests to come up with a foreign policy defined by its moral concerns, a commitment to anti-colonialism and international cooperation, and non-alignment 'on the merits'. These goals and interests were underpinned by many of Nehru's own beliefs and assumptions: an exaggerated sense of India's importance as 'the cultural fountainhead of the new Asia',[14] an instinctive affinity for the notion of 'Asianism' that he axiomatically assumed was shared by China and Southeast Asia, a